

After a successful few years, the Smartmodem series and other modems died out due to increased competition from other modem manufacturers like USR and Telebit. Another reason for its tapering away was that Hayes was betting on ISDN to take off in a big way and had a line of products ready.

July: Microsoft Acquires DOS

Earlier known as QDOS (Quick and Dirty Operating System), MS-DOS was launched in July 1981. It lasted until Microsoft stopped development in 2000. By then, it had had eight version updates.

Originally written by Tim Paterson for Seattle Computer Products, it was bought over by Microsoft the same year. MS-DOS closely resembled CP/M-80, an OS of the time known for its stability amongst the 16-bit OSes. Microsoft granted the rights to use MS-DOS to all computer manufacturers, which allowed them to customise its name.

Throughout computer history, therefore, we come across names like PC-DOS, TandyDOS, CompaqDOS, and more.



What the earliest DOS programs looked like...

MS-DOS kept evolving by adding support for the 320 KB floppy, non-English languages, networking, then the 720 KB floppy. It added Long File Name support on version 7.0; this removed the eight-character limit for file names. Support for the FAT32 filesystem was added, too. MS-DOS 8.0, embedded in Windows Me, was the last version from Microsoft.

August: The IBM PC!

IBM, the company earlier known for its employee time-keeping machines and punched-card systems, finally decided to foray into